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TOMORROW'S CHILD

**Navigating Your Toddler's
First Days Of School**

**Unveiling Geometry's
Cultural Tapestry**

**Nourishing
the Whole Child**



TOMORROW'S CHILD

The International Magazine for Montessori Families

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This 80-page full-color publication is a wonderful resource for anyone seeking to de-mystify Montessori. It addresses topics such as the history and philosophy of Montessori; offers a guided tour of the Montessori classroom; and serves as an illustrated guide to dozens of wonderful Montessori materials. This mini-encyclopedia of Montessori is newly redesigned and contains new sections on Infant/Toddler and Montessori Secondary programs. It is a must-have resource for anyone interested in Montessori, and one that parents will surely refer to throughout their child's Montessori experience.



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"How do we inspire children, throughout their early years and beyond, to develop healthy habits and food preferences that will remain stable for life?"

NOURISHING THE WHOLE CHILD, PG.18



0-3 Years

Right from the Start

0-3 Years

Right from the Start

Navigating Your Toddler's First Days at a Montessori School

A GUIDE FOR PARENTS OF TODDLERS

by **Maly Peña**



As a parent, the transition from home to school can be a whirlwind of emotions. Excitement mingles with anxiety, and there's a mix of anticipation and uncertainty about how your child will fare in this new environment. But fear not; you're not alone in this journey. Whether it's tears of joy or trepidation, the experiences you're going through are valid, and there's support available to help ease the transition for both you and your child.

Based on a webinar hosted by Kathy Leitch, the Executive Director of the International Montessori Council (IMC), we want to share some insights and tips to make this transition smoother for everyone involved.

Do you have an infant or toddler at home who is getting ready to enter a Montessori program? Then this article is for you!

The Prepared Environment and How to Prepare Yourself

In Montessori, we often talk about the prepared environment, which is more than just the physical environment. The prepared environment also includes our personal environment and our attitude. Montessori training even includes a whole section on the Spiritual Preparation of the Teacher. While you don't need to do that, it may help to do some introspection. The confidence parents display to children before they enter the classroom will help them prepare for what their experience will be.

Rest assured that parents often have mixed feelings about bringing their little one to school for the first time. We may be excited to give them an opportunity to meet other children and to have both educational stimulation and some socialization. The flip side of excitement is anxiety

about how they will adapt to the changes in their routines and environments. Will they separate easily? Will there be tears? We may even be concerned about shedding a tear ourselves. What will we do if that happens?

Maybe you feel a little celebratory, thinking that you've made it to a particular milestone, or you've been on a waiting list at a Montessori school, and you finally have an opportunity to have your child join. Wherever you are in this range (or if you're feeling all these at once), we are here to tell you that all feelings are valid, and it is only natural and healthy to feel them! One of the main things to remember is that the teachers and the school leaders have been through this before. They are there to support you and to help you and your child through this transition.

Start Building Your School Partnership

Speaking of learning about your school's policies, you might want to learn about the protocols in advance. For example:

- How will your child be greeted?
- Where is the appropriate drop-off area?
- Are you expected to stay with your child, or is this the time that you will be leaving your child?

Get to know the protocols at your school because they may vary from others.

DO YOU HAVE
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IS FOR YOU!



Attend Your Parent Orientation Meeting

A cornerstone of Montessori is the deep sense of community that is built within a classroom and how much a Montessori guide knows your child and your family. Communication in the first three years in a Montessori program is probably the single most important thing a school and a family can do. The parent orientation meeting is the perfect opportunity to ask all your questions and learn more about the daily schedule. It is also where you can share a bit about your daily logistics and find some middle ground.

Parents can comfortably ask questions, and teachers can begin to understand and know each child's needs and what they are trying to communicate, especially in our pre-verbal children. If you are a two-parent family, have both parents attend and take notes, because you'll hear part of it and your partner might hear part of it, and total retention of information is important.



TIP: If your toddler is going to be bringing a lunchbox to school, think about the entire process: Do they know how to open their lunchbox independently? How much support do they need? Are there containers inside that they can practice with at home prior to starting school? This will make them feel comfortable and familiar with the routines in the school day.



Expect Schedule Changes

Be aware about changes that may occur during those first six weeks before things start to settle. Your child's appetite might dramatically change during the first days at school. Children may suddenly eat three times as much, or they may eat almost nothing because they're talking all through lunch with their new best friends. Nap times might change as well. While these are all changes, don't panic. It will stabilize over time.

You may also experience some regressions when the child first starts; the transition does not always go smoothly. At first, a child may be thrilled. Everything's fine, and then, two weeks later, it hits them: "Oh my gosh, did you mean I have to do this every day?" So, we want to be aware that it doesn't mean something bad happened. It doesn't mean that they can't come back to school. Stay calm, support them, keep that confidence, communicate with your child's teacher that you're getting some resistance, and they can help support you in that part of the transition. Usually within a week, two weeks, a month, most children will be having the best time of their lives and don't want to go home at the end of the day. So, just try and stick it out and stay positive.





Some schools create several extra steps to ease families into the process. If you can, take advantage of those that work best for your family. Some of our favorites are:

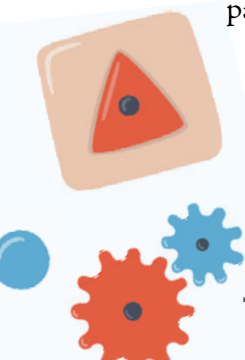
Home Visits

A home visit is a way for your child and the teacher to begin to build trust and understanding at home, where your child feels comfortable and safe. The home visit will also help the teacher understand what the child is communicating, whether they're hungry, or they need to move. We really get to learn what their cues are and how responsive we can be. Home visits allow children to meet their teachers in the comfort and familiarity of home with their parents. Home visits start the process of building trust and understanding between your child and the teacher. Home visits help make the transition from home to school easier for your child, the teacher, and you.

Moving to a new environment may be confusing, nonetheless. The younger the child is, the more confusing it might be for them. However, if the school and the home can stick to almost the same routines, children will have some consistency, and that will help them feel more comfortable. Bear in mind that life is full of change; children will learn to adjust. Routines will change, weekends will be different, grandparents might visit, and consistency helps to smooth the way.

Phase-In Programs

Phasing into a new program often helps children to gradually adjust to their new environment. Phase-in visits generally consist of starting with maybe just an hour visit with the parent present. If it's a new school year, you might have a few new students come together at a time with their parent to visit for about an hour.



They will get familiar with the environment and with the teacher and other caregivers. Subsequently, the teacher would periodically increase the amount of time they come

to school each day. They might come for a half day and, if possible, the parent would leave for a short period of time. This starts conveying the message to the child that, yes, my parent will come back for me.

The main goal for this is to build the trust that these adults are okay, the environment is safe, and your parent will come back to get you. A phase-in process can take anywhere from about three days up to two weeks for some children. Sometimes, even if the school doesn't provide this, certain children will insist on it. Some can't make it through the whole day. If this is the case, teachers may call their parents to set up a phase-in program, even if it's not a school-wide policy.

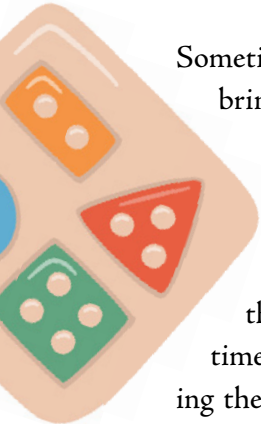
Some children are ready to go and they're the first ones in the door trying new things; whereas, some kids want to sit at the door and watch for a week, and that's valid.

Meet the Teacher and the Classroom

We love it when parents have the opportunity to observe the classroom environment, and we encourage you to pay special attention especially in these infant and toddler en-



vironments. Watch closely to see how the teacher responds to different needs or how they read the cues of these youngest students. Your child's Montessori teacher will most likely give you signs to watch for and will help guide you so you know what to expect.



Sometimes, the teacher will suggest that the family bring a small stand-up frame containing a family picture with them to the teacher and parent meeting. This is an opportunity for the family and the child to talk about the picture. Then they find a special place for the picture on a counter or cabinet. Sometimes the child will just hold their picture. Holding the picture comforts them; they are reassured that this is their family and that they are coming back for them. Children often go back to their family photo midyear and share it with their friends. The connection evolves as their language develops. It is not unusual for a teacher to overhear a child telling a story about their sibling, parent, guardian, grandparent, or whoever happens to be in the picture.

The Parent Handbook

The Parent Handbook is another source of information. Schools generally know the most frequently asked questions and seek to answer these in the handbook. The more familiar you are with the Parent Handbook, the more

comfortable you're going to be with the process of what's happening.

Communicating with Your Child's Teacher

Find out what your school's protocols are for contacting your teacher. Maybe there's a time after school when they can take/make phone calls. Perhaps you can email or use a particular communication system that your school has; if so, you will want to understand this process so that you feel comfortable.

Your school may have something like: Bright Wheel, Masori, Compass, Transform, or Transparent Classroom. These are wonderful ways to communicate daily, and your school will probably use one of these methods. Generally, the parents must accept an invitation to have access to the communication portal, so watch for that from your school. If your school doesn't have a formal communication method, don't hesitate to make a few suggestions. Generally, the younger the child, the more communication you will receive. Communication will usually include



informing you about how your child did during the day and what their schedule looked like that day (e.g., if they slept well or if they had any times when they were out of sorts).

Dismissal and arrival are not the times to ask questions; those are sacred interactions. When a parent is giving us their child for the day, we want to make that interaction as positive and as focused on the child as we possibly can. We always call that the “reunification time,” the time that parent and child are coming back together. To have adult conversations during those times really takes the child out of the process. We want to help support them.



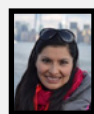
Parent Ambassadors

It is great when you can ask for help from seasoned parents, who are eager to take new parents under their wings. This is always valuable, because schools are not just about the community of children; they are about the community of families as well. Often these interactions spark lifelong friendships. A benefit would be the possibility of getting a different parent perspective (not a different policy or procedure answer) but an alternative viewpoint. Perhaps it's a parent in their child's classroom who's been there a little longer or has a child in the next level.

In Conclusion

You're taking a step into a big new world, and it's okay to have mixed feelings about that: be excited and scared and

know that the people next to you with their kids coming in, feel the same way. We will all learn together. The teachers will learn about your children, and you will learn about the school. It becomes a new community every year; it's a wonderful thing. There may be bumps along the road, but there's a reason Montessori teachers do it for 20, 30, 40 years. It's because every year it becomes something bigger than just one person. It becomes a whole supportive community, and that is what makes it rather magical. ■



Maly Peña, born and raised in Mexico, embarked on a diverse educational journey that began in Montessori and international schools. She earned her bachelor's degree in sociology and her master's in political science from the University of Fribourg in Switzerland. With a career focused on parent-school relations and fundraising, Maly has lived internationally in Europe, Asia, and USA for most of her adult life. Now, she enjoys a vibrant life in Mexico City with her husband and their dog, Queso, delighting in the city's rich culture, hiking trails, and culinary delights.

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The Advantage of Mixed-Aged Classrooms by Alex Gallen



When we have visitors and tours in our classroom, I often wonder what parents and caregivers think when they see our mixed-age students working together. I see these families walk into our classroom observing something most of them probably haven't seen before. I was a student once, too, in a traditional classroom, where all the students worked with the same material at the same time, using worksheets.

I also remember some students falling behind and trying to play catch-up while others were ahead of the game. Regardless of our individual, unique situation, we just had to do the same thing at the same time. In kindergarten, we jumped straight into abstract work, which created other challenges. We were not allowed to ask our classmates for help, take a break, move around the room, and certainly would never think of using the bathroom without asking for permission.

There is so much research now showing the importance of moving while learning, as it ignites areas of the brain that improve concentration; increase retention; and relieve stress.

What I love about the flow in a Montessori classroom is how students move slowly from concrete material to abstract lessons as they become ready. I wish I had experienced the

same type of lessons and process during my early learning and throughout my academic growth, especially in math. I sincerely believe I would have been a better student had I developed a foundation in math based on a concrete understanding.

It is beautiful to see students work while they get help from their peers, increasing interaction, and developing role-model skills. The older children build patience, tolerance, empathy, and confidence. They inspire the younger children, who are learning different skills, (social, emotional, cognitive, and academic) from their older peers.

Mixed-age group classrooms contain a diversity of material that challenges the children's unique needs in different areas. Through peer education, children work together and learn from each other. The children learn at a relaxed pace, without the stress that comes from competition and comparison with their peers that is found in many traditional learning environments. A learning environment that prioritizes individual goals and progress with peer education fosters a positive, collaborative classroom, where children can be themselves and flourish at their own pace. ■



Alexandra "Alex" Gallen is a Primary guide at NewGate Montessori School. Alex earned her BA in psychology from the University of South Florida and is certified in Early Childhood from the Montessori Accreditation Council for Teacher Education (MACTE). Alex is originally from Lima, Peru, she moved to Florida in 2001. Alex taught Spanish for several years before getting Montessori certified and enjoys integrating Spanish into her lessons. Alex first came across the Montessori Method while looking for schools for her children, and she made it her mission to raise her three children this way.

Unveiling Geometry's Cultural Tapestry

A Journey of Discovery
& Connection

by Ola Elserwi

The ancient Greeks regarded drawing geometric constructions using only a compass and straightedge as essential for proving theorems. They discovered that this method facilitated problem analysis through the figures created, leading to solutions.

Throughout my educational journey, I stood out as the geometry geek among my classmates. Teachers often praised my ability to grasp and navigate geometric concepts swiftly. Growing up with an engineer for a father, I was led to believe that my aptitude for engineering stemmed from his genes, which seemingly multiplied the geometry neurons in my brain.

For months, my classmates and I dedicated ourselves to memorizing formulas, theorems, and prescribed steps for writing proofs. We did all this without truly critiquing or comprehending the process or applying our knowledge to meaningful contexts. This left us continually asking the question: *Why are we learning this?* For many, geometry became synonymous with daunting complexity, evoking memories of classes filled with perplexing theorems and bewildering formulas. While memorization may have aided some in solving certain problems, it did little to demystify geometry or foster a genuine affinity for the subject.

When the time arrived to pass on my geometry knowledge to my daughter, who was more inclined towards nature, art, and social activities, I experienced resistance. Her school's emphasis on rote memorization caused her to develop a fear of geometry, along with the belief that she was prone to making mistakes, which led her to find geometry difficult and boring. Despite my confidence, my attempts to assist her with personally tested tools, as well as hiring a geometry tutor, yielded tenuous results. As I wondered how to proceed, I questioned whether she would intuit concepts in geometry as effortlessly as I had, given our shared genetic makeup. However, her journey with geometry diverged from mine, marking a significant turning point for me.

In our three-dimensional, ever-changing world, children naturally develop a significant reservoir of geometric knowledge, which Montessori referred to as *engrams*. The geometry curriculum should harness this intuitive understanding to enhance and formalize students' foundational knowledge. Presenting geometry solely as a stand-alone, content-driven subject in a linear fashion, with time constraints and a rigid set of standards to cover, promotes



premature abstraction. This approach can dampen students' enthusiasm and deprive them of the opportunity for self-paced exploration and a deeper understanding of the interconnectedness of life. Abstraction also severs the connection between geometry and its presence in nature, art, and human-made structures.

There is nothing in the intellect which is not first in the senses. — Aristotle

To facilitate a smooth transition to sensible abstraction, it is essential to 'scaffold' learners as they progress from simple to more complex levels of understanding, gradually shedding external support. This process involves building upon learners' existing knowledge to prepare them for new concepts. It necessitates a focus on enhancing learners' comprehension of geometric relationships, not because they lack the ability to grasp them, but because they require immersive, qualitative, and hands-on experiences over time to develop critical-thinking and visualization skills. This

development occurs through reflection on actions, communication of observations and conclusions, and the cultivation of a robust vocabulary of geometric terms. In order to ensure that learners become confident and proficient, this approach must be integrated, dynamic, and tailored to leverage student culture, interests, language, available technology, manipulatives, and other resources.

Integrating geometry into our spiral curriculum cultivates interconnectedness across diverse learning domains, enabling children to explore its applications and forge meaningful connections between theoretical concepts and real-world experiences. By showcasing practical examples, such as architects utilizing circles to bolster structural resilience and environmental sustainability; plumbers determining offset angles to regulate fluid flow rates; and dentists employing angles for precise tool and material placement, students gain a deeper appreciation for the relevance of geometry in everyday life.

Tracing the historical evolution of geometric knowledge from practical applications to abstract theories reveals the contributions of various civilizations. The Greeks, for instance, developed theorems and proofs through structured

discussions that emphasized clear argumentation, giving rise to Greek Logic. However, the roots of geometry stretch back to ancient Egypt and Mesopotamia, where practical applications flourished alongside agriculture, architecture, calendars, astronomy, and commerce, all facilitated by the presence of rivers. This progression prompted Aristotle to propose his peripatetic axiom, "There is nothing in the intellect which is not first in the senses," a concept later embraced by Montessori, who emphasized the integration of hands-on learning with intellectual pursuits.

By immersing students in the historical evolution of geometry, from practical applications to abstract concepts, we equip them with the skills to analyze and elucidate past challenges. This positions them to discern patterns in the contemporary landscape; thereby, offering a vital perspective for comprehending and ultimately resolving, present and future issues.

As I stepped into an Upper Elementary Montessori classroom, I was so excited about teaching geometry in a manner that enables and allows students (and me) to make discoveries through geometry's intrinsic cultural richness at different scales. Teaching geometry through its cultural lenses entails including diversity in anything that has to do with how people live, such as art, recreation, beliefs, languages, traditions, stories, and folklore, ways of organization, ways of interaction with the environment, and attitudes.

At the beginning of the year, I introduced the *yin-yang* design to my students, inviting them to share its story and significance. I found joy in hearing their narratives, and it gave them the opportunity to teach me. Yet, they needed more certainty regarding how to utilize a compass and straightedge to draw it. We analyzed the design, discussed each component, and then I guided them with some cues before stepping back to observe. What fascinated me was their dedication to perfecting and refining their personalized creations, as well as their "AHA" moments when they saw their ideas come to life, indicating their comprehension. Consequently, I adopted a construction-based learning approach throughout the year.



Thus, drawing comes to satisfy a need for expression, as does language; ...the effort to perfect such expression is very similar to that which the child makes when he is spurred on to perfect his language in order to see his thoughts translated into reality.

— Maria Montessori, *The Advanced Montessori Method*, volume II, part V

Our exploration of geometric constructions extended to various cultures, including the Babylonians, Chinese, Indians, Islamics, Africans, Native Americans, Dutch, and numerous others. Delving into the narratives behind these constructions allowed my students to gain a profound insight into how our ancestors approached problems and persevered through trials, hardships, and triumphs to enrich the world. As they delved into their ancestors' contributions and stories related to geometry, my students found connections between themselves and their forebears, fostering a deeper appreciation for their cultural heritage.

I provided explicit instruction in construction techniques, covering the proper handling and use of a compass and straightedge, the angle and sharpness of pencils, types of leads, erasers, erasing techniques, hand placement, and cushioning under the paper. This equipped my students with the skills to think critically, visualize, critique, discover, conclude, and comprehend geometry concepts over time.

I vividly recall my students' fascination when I introduced certain constructions using only a compass and straightedge, such as the circumscribed circle of a square, finding the midpoint of a line, bisecting an angle, and doubling the borders of a hexagon. Some students were inspired to explore alternative techniques to execute these constructions beyond those I had taught. While this journey involved a considerable amount of trial and error, the joy and empowerment derived from their exploration and subsequent learning were evident. As I met with them to discuss their investigation, I also gained valuable insights.

In teaching geometric constructions, I offered multiple approaches and techniques to accommodate different learning styles. This ensured that students understood geometry as a field with a spectrum of ideas rather than a single solution. This approach encouraged my students

to pursue their own research questions, develop innovative geometric designs, and delve into historical contexts.

Geometry transformed into a captivating treasure hunt as my students explored the intricate Islamic geometric con-

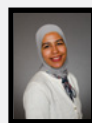


structions and admired the beauty of biomorphic art, also known as Arabesque, from various regions and eras. This journey fostered divergent thinking, creative problem-solving, and the development of logical reasoning skills among my students. They became deeply engaged in investigating, experimenting, and creating their own constructions, sharing the joy of discovery with one another. Through geometric constructions, they delved into spatial relationships, properties of geometric figures, transformations and modeling, measurement, and deductive reasoning. This immersive experience allowed them to perceive the world through a geometric lens, truly encountering geometry in their everyday lives. They met geometry!

During the editing process of this article, an interesting event occurred: One of my students approached me seeking guidance on drawing various types of bridges. This prompted me to initiate a study unit on the historical aspects of bridges. To scaffold their learning journey, students completed a KWL chart—a graphic organizer that assists students in arranging information prior to, during,

and following a unit or lesson, to express their background knowledge, interests, and inquiries regarding the topic. Among their curiosities were inquiries about the origins of bridges, their quantity, drawing techniques, construction methods, and materials utilized. Exploring these questions offers insight into their fascination with historical origins, pioneering figures, and the artistic aspects of design.

As I journey through the realms of geometry, my comprehension has matured, leading me to embrace a multi-dimensional approach to teaching that integrates language, art, history, and science with this discipline. Geometry serves as a unifying force, a universal language of expression that bridges diverse subjects and people together. It stands as a universal language capable of fostering peace and unity. Let us continue to delve into the cultural depth of geometry, recognizing its importance for humanity's collective understanding. ■



Over a decade ago, **Ola Elserwi** embraced the calling to become a Montessori teacher, infusing her pedagogy with creativity and passion. Today, as an Upper Elementary Montessori educator, she harmonizes her love for teaching with artistic expression, Islamic geometric designs, and biomorphic patterns.

Her accomplishments are helping the creation of pioneering Montessori Arabic language curriculum, adopted by schools across Egypt and beyond. In addition to academia, Ola finds solace in crafting intricate geometric designs, honoring her deep reverence for Islamic art and culture. When not shaping young minds or designing curriculum materials, she immerses herself in nature, traversing scenic landscapes, embracing physical activity, and exploring literature.

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How to Deliver a *Powerful, Yet Meaningful*, Apology to your Teenage Child

by Kath Kvols

Editor's note: Montessori education is all about modeling the behavior we expect our children to learn. As they grow, we might not teach them how to wait for their turn to speak, but we might very well enforce their empathy, social skills and model the way we want them to think and reflect when something *happens* and they arrive late.

These suggestions can be applied with friends and family members. Children often want an explanation for your behavior. In this case, make a very short explanation. Children often want to be reassured that you aren't angry with them and that you still love them.

Being more interested in their feelings than your own feelings is the key to a successful, powerful, and meaningful apology.

It is virtually impossible not to find yourself in this position. We hope that using these guidelines will help restore and enhance your relationship rather than create even more distance. ■

You are 20 minutes late for a lunch appointment with your teen. Here are some *do's* and *don'ts* for making a powerful yet meaningful apology.



Don't gaslight (making the other person question their reality).
"You must have heard me wrong. I said one-ish." Comments like these put the responsibility for your actions on someone else.

Don't put the blame on them.
"You should have called me if you were worried."

Don't make excuses for your behavior.
"My last appointment ran over time." They are not interested in your excuses at this moment!

Don't talk about how you feel.
"I am so embarrassed. I am usually on time." Again, they are not interested in your feelings at this moment!

Don't over apologize. "I am REALLY sorry. This was so inconsiderate of me." This can be misconstrued as being more concerned about making sure they are not angry with you than you are about their feelings.

Don't make false promises. "I promise I'll never be late again." It is impossible to make this promise in the future, and it doesn't alleviate the other person's negative feelings.



Do take responsibility for your actions.
"You are right. I am REALLY late!"

Do validate their feelings.
"You have a right to be irritated with me."

Do admit you were wrong.
"I didn't watch my time effectively."

Do empathize with how they might be feeling.
"It must have been irritating to wait this long."

Do sincerely apologize once,
while making good eye contact with them.

Do make amends for your behavior.
"How about I buy your lunch for inconveniencing you?"



Kathryn Kvols is the president of APEC, a worldwide parent-training network that teaches her life-changing course, "Redirecting Children's Behavior." The course teaches skill-building strategies to families. They emphasize teamwork, creating win-win situations and effectively avoiding power struggles using kind-but-firm methods promoted by Dr. Alfred Adler and Dr. Rudolf Dreikurs.

Kathryn has a bachelor of science degree in psychology and social work with a minor in education from Concordia College in Minnesota. Kathryn and her husband, Brian Harper, reside in Gainesville, Florida and have a blended family of five children: Brianna, Tyler, Chloe, Emily, and Amy. Visit her website at www.apecparenting.com for more information.



Nourishing the Whole Child

HEALTHY EATING AND WELLNESS AT DESERT GARDEN MONTESSORI

by Cassie Tolman

Montessori education embraces the whole child to create a nourishing environment that fosters curiosity, creativity, connection to the natural world, and respect for the earth. Encouraging healthy eating and caring for our bodies is part of the philosophy, but how do we integrate these practices into our daily lives? How do we inspire children throughout their early years and beyond to develop healthy habits and food preferences that will remain stable for life?

From infants all the way through high school, healthy eating and wellness are not only an integral part of the curriculum but interwoven into daily life at Desert Garden Montessori (Phoenix, AZ). Each morning, as the sun rises and the school begins to come alive, a wooden farm cart in the center of campus is stocked with baskets and jars containing daily whole-food snacks. Students from each

classroom bring reusable bags to select a wholesome home-made snack that always includes fresh, seasonal, locally grown produce.

Today's snack is Cinnamon and Maple-Seed Granola with Oat Milk and Ana Apples. The harvest, along with nutrition information about ingredients, is brought back to the classroom to be prepared mindfully and shared with each child. In the infant room, Ms. Kinnari printed photos of oats, pumpkin seeds, and apples and clipped them to the wall next to the snack table so that the babies could begin to be introduced to the whole foods in today's snack. This simple process builds a foundation that helps children develop intuitive, healthy eating from an early age.

Just past the Wellness Garden Market, towards the end of campus, Chef Val and her small team are getting an early

start preparing lunch in the organic kitchen, where nutritious meals are made from scratch and shared with love each day. Like the snacks, lunches are centered around whole, seasonal ingredients. This month, Chef Val is highlighting lentils, quinoa, Brussel sprouts, and dill. These seasonal ingredients are superstars that will appear in new and creative ways throughout the month in dishes like Lentil Mujadara, Balsamic Glazed Brussel Sprouts, Garden Salad with Cucumber Dill Dressing, and Quinoa Fried Rice.

Behind the kitchen, a greenhouse is nestled underneath velvet mesquite trees, where some of the herbs and greens used in the organic lunch are grown. From seed to table, this is where children of all ages care for their garden as well as harvest, prepare, and eat the produce. Inside the greenhouse, fresh herbs, leafy greens, edible flowers, and vegetables are grown using vertical tower gardens. Tower gardens are aeroponic systems that can produce year-round in a variety of spaces. They use 95 percent less water and grow much faster than traditional gardening, making them ideal for small urban settings.

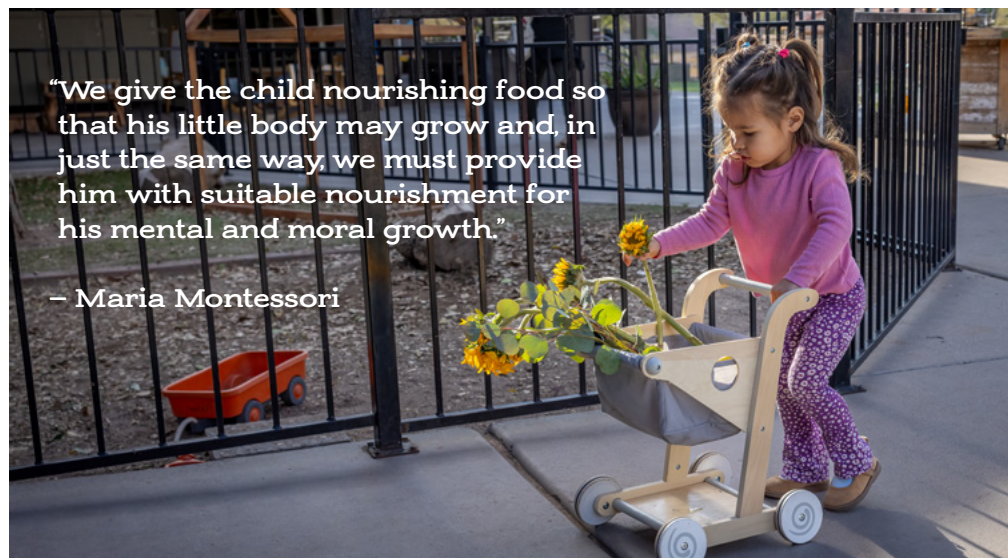
This week in wellness class, primary and lower elementary students are learning about whole grains. The children start by gathering in a circle in the grass, where they are introduced to the lesson with glass jars containing a variety of whole grains: brown rice, millet, quinoa, barley, amaranth, and oats. They learn that grains are the seeds of grasses,

and seeds have the power to nourish our entire body and bring the earth to life. The lesson helps children understand the difference between whole and refined grains by sharing that when a grain is processed, some of the layers (and valuable nutrients) are removed.

After circle time, children wash their hands and move to the Tasting Table, where plant-based chef and holistic nutrition educator Cassie Tolman presents a lesson on making Brown Rice and Millet Onigiri. Each child rolls cooked brown rice and millet into a ball, makes a 'nest' in the center, and then fills it with edamame and colorful veggies. They form their Onigiri back into a ball and roll it in toasted sesame seeds. Now it is time to enjoy our Brown Rice and Millet Onigiri! Many children raise their hands, asking for seconds and thirds.

Once the Onigiri have been enjoyed, they move to the Eco Exploration Table, where they learn about the calming power of herbs, while making Grain & Lavender Sachets with Montessori-certified teacher and tower gardener Chelsey James. Dried chamomile flowers, harvested from our greenhouse, are blended with brown rice and a few drops of relaxing lavender oil. The children take deep breaths and relax, pouring the blend into cloth bags and wrapping them with twine to take home. Later that afternoon, older students will work in smaller groups, learning how to grow, prepare, and eat real living foods from

the earth. In the greenhouse, Ms. Chelsey teaches aeroponic gardening while Ms. Cassie collaborates with students in the organic kitchen to develop healthy recipes for a soon-to-be-published cookbook. These activities represent a snapshot of a single week in Wellness Education at Desert Garden Montessori. Other lessons in the holistic curriculum include: Embracing the Whole-Foods Rainbow; What is Taste? What is Flavor?; Eating with the Seasons;



"We give the child nourishing food so that his little body may grow and, in just the same way, we must provide him with suitable nourishment for his mental and moral growth."

— Maria Montessori

All Food Has a Story; Seeds We Eat & Plant; Legumes (Celebrating Squash); Corn (an Ancient Staple); Winter Solstice: Nourishing our Immune System; Microbiome (Caring for our Inner Garden); Mindful Eating & Joyful Movement; and more.

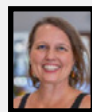


The Wellness Education Program at Desert Garden Montessori provides hands-on experiences that connect students to food, their bodies, the Earth, and each other. This holistic curriculum offers students experiential learning opportunities to facilitate culinary literacy and gardening, deepen their relationship with food, and develop agency to create wellness in their own lives and their communities.

Rooted in the belief that children will only learn healthy habits if they are practicing them every day, the core pillars of this program are:

- **Gardening:** Growing our own food increases access to fresh, nutrient-dense food, builds connection to the Earth, and creates a living classroom.
- **Embracing the Whole-Foods Rainbow:** Whole foods work synergistically to supply all of nature's nutrients in a perfect package, providing us with vital life-force energy.
- **Cooking:** We prepare nutritious, healthy foods with (and for) our children. By doing, one learns.
- **Supporting Local:** We support local farmers by purchasing and serving organic, seasonal, locally grown foods at our school.
- **Replenishing the Earth:** Our daily lives replenish the earth for future generations. We apply the 5 R's: Refuse, Reduce, Reuse, Recycle, and Rot through our Food-to-Food Compost Program and by reusing materials that might otherwise be sent to the landfill.
- **Nourishing the Whole Child:** We nourish the whole child (mind, body, and spirit) with natural, unprocessed foods and integrative health practices. We also teach about the world's interconnectedness.

Inviting children into the kitchen, engaging their senses with fresh, seasonal, delicious ingredients, and creating positive food experiences can be incorporated at home. Making space to integrate small practices into each day has the power to create a ripple effect in your family's life. Start small by planting an herb garden, shopping for weekly groceries at your local farmer's market, volunteering at a community garden, or trying a new recipe centered around whole foods. Take it slow and at a pace that works for you and your family. A healthy lifestyle is not about perfection but about the continuum of healthy living. We hope this article has inspired you to cultivate joyful wellness in your home. ■



Cassie Tolman is a holistic nutrition educator for The Wellness Wheel for Life program at Desert Garden Montessori. Cassie's skill and experience in the kitchen are mixed with a heaping dose of imagination and an appetite for new flavors. She is a graduate of the Chef's Training Program at The Natural Gourmet Institute, NYC, and is currently working towards her master of science in Nutrition and Integrative Health. Many years ago, Cassie helped begin the organic lunch program at DGM. Later she founded and operated Pomegranate Café, an organic plant-based eatery in Phoenix, for over a decade. Cassie's passion for cooking and teaching is rooted in a desire to empower people of all ages to live a vibrant life while creating a healthier Earth and a sustainable future.

Candid Conversations

PARENTS & ADULT
MONTESSORI CHILDREN

by Duna Strachan



The sun shone on the gleaming wooden boxes, the healthy plants, and the happy rabbit living quietly in the corner as I followed my daughter into a Montessori classroom for the first time. I had searched the Phoenix Valley for a place for my two-year-old to spend the mornings while I worked on my master's degree. The daycares I visited were loud, smelly, and unnerving with the constant sound of crying. Then, just like in the folk story, I found just what I had been looking for, practically in my own backyard. Rainbow Montessori School was housed in a ranch-style house with a large patio, where children were welcome to work at any time. There were glass plates on the snack shelf, enticing materials in each room, and peaceful adults helping when needed. I observed a class and couldn't wait for my daughter to start. The teacher would bring her out to the car line each day and say something like, "Lina worked on the color boxes today." "The color boxes? What are the color boxes?" I needed to know.

From then, I became the nosey parent, always asking what was in the boxes and what did they do? I came to every parent night and couldn't get enough of this Montessori thing. We had since moved to Utah and immediately enrolled Lina in a Montessori school there, continuing my questioning of every little thing. One day the director of the school asked why I didn't take the training. "Oh, no. I'm not a teacher. I'm a scientist," I said. But I started to think about it. I read a little of Dr. Montessori's work and realized she was a scientist, too.

Decades later both of my children, and now their children, have been through our school. Lina and Leith both did well in college, pursued careers in areas far removed from education, but came back to our school to teach and to lead. They are happy, successful adults who enjoy their days, no matter what they are doing. They have always been good at academics; they read a lot; they are interested in many things and never stop learning. They are students of life. But as a parent, I would say that the most important thing they got from their Montessori years was that sense of mindfulness, of purpose, of knowing how to solve a problem, of acting independently and confidently, of enjoying every moment.

I recently attended the International Montessori Congress in Bangkok, where a group of Montessori adolescents spoke. This presentation came at the end of the conference after many adult presenters spoke of the trying times in our world today. One of the adolescents concluded her presentation by saying that she listened to what the adults had been saying and just wanted to reply, "We've got this." ■



Duna Strachan, MEd, is Founder and Executive Director of Soaring Wings International Montessori School in Park City, Utah, mother of two grown, happy and successful Montessori children and grandmother of five Montessori grandchildren with all kinds of potential!



Bridgeview Montessori

A School that Lives Its Mission and Core Values

by Suzanne Lawson

Bridgeview Montessori is a 10,000 sq. ft. school designed for 95 students. It has six classrooms, a dedicated art studio, a science room, a library, a kitchen, a separate space for before-and-after-care, and small conference rooms. The school sits on 1.25 acres along the Cape Cod Canal in Sagamore, Massachusetts and has a Children's House and Lower and Upper Elementary classes.

When families walk through the doors at Bridgeview Montessori, they feel the many hands that have created the scaffolding that allows children to grow towards being authentic human beings with confidence, integrity, and grit. Families blossom into a community with shared responsibility, loyalty, and trust. It is palpable.



The school was founded by parents who wanted an inspired Montessori education for their children. Jean Rice and Palmer True had witnessed the power of Maria Montessori's pedagogy when their twin sons were in a local

WE CULTIVATE CREATIVE PROCESS • WE GROW EMPOWERED AND RESILIENT PEOPLE • WE HOLD COMMUNITY CLOSE

Montessori Children's House, but when the boys were ready for their Elementary years, no option existed in their Cape Cod or South Coast Massachusetts community. Thus, in 1999, Bridgeview Montessori came to be.

In those early years, the school grappled a bit with their identity, wondering if a Montessori Elementary school could thrive in a community in which public school was the norm. Yet, those visionaries never questioned the school's importance in providing something essential for the community. They imagined a school where many different types of learners could feel inspired, be authentic, build confidence, have a voice, learn peacefully side by side, actively listen, and appreciate *quiet*.

In 2007, Palmer and his wife realized that in order to guarantee the longevity of their wonderful school and to ensure that it maintained their original vision of Montessori Elementary, the school needed to be a non-profit independent school run by a board of trustees.

Palmer encouraged those passionate about the school to change its status to that of a not-for-profit organization. After eight months of hard work, the school's design team (made up of parents; faculty, outside educators, and community members) created and filed the charter and documentation to gain 501(c)(3) status. This important piece of the school's history speaks to the passion, dedication, wisdom, perseverance, and good ol' grit that pervades Bridgeview Montessori's classrooms, outdoor learning spaces, offices, and parking lot with our families and caregivers! Having first leased the building and property, the board was eventually able to secure the financing to purchase the building and property from Palmer.

Bridgeview's teachers are Montessori-trained educators who have dedicated their professional lives to guiding students to be the best they can be academically, socially, and emotionally. They collaborate with each other; they



actively seek professional development; and they strive to create a family/school partnership for each individual upon entering our classrooms. The administrative team is small by design, consisting only of the Head of School; Director of Children's House; Assistant Head of School/Director of Admissions; and Administrative Coordinator. Decision making is collaborative and, in keeping with its stated core value, *Inspire Every Voice*. The teachers and specialists are autonomous yet actively collaborate with (and learn from) each other. They have over 50 years of collective work experience at Bridgeview Montessori.



Bridgeview Montessori has working parents, military parents, single parents, foster parents, grandparents raising their grandchildren, and LGBTQI parents. Some parents apply for and receive financial aid; some parents pay full tuition. Some parents are familiar with independent school culture and Montessori specifically; some are new to Montessori and to private school. Some families choose to keep



storm. It is an environment where everyone feels safe to do their best work and safe to share those growing edges. Bridgeview Montessori's growth and longevity is that of the collective. ■



their children at Bridgeview from 2.9 through 12 years old; some are only there for preschool; and some come to us after having been disappointed with the traditional schooling provided by their towns. These varied backgrounds and experiences add to the richness of the school community.

Central to this vibrant community are its students. Each individual who walks through the doors does so with the raw material needed to implant, grow, and blossom. That student may be a math wizard, a dinosaur fan, an avid reader, or a soon-to-be toilet trained two-year-old. In any case, these students learn what they are good at. They become emboldened, inspired, and independent.

In a society where childhood can be rushed, technology is everywhere, and frenetic schedules are more the norm than the anomaly, Bridgeview Montessori is vital for those families and educators searching for that safe port in the



Suzanne Lawson, Assistant Head of School /

Director of Admissions, joined the faculty at Bridgeview Montessori in 2008 after spending several years raising her two children. Prior to that time, Suzanne had spent many years in teaching, curriculum development, and faculty development in independent boarding and day schools, most recently at the Shady Hill School in Cambridge. She is very familiar with Montessori education, having been a Montessori student herself from age 3 through the 5th grade at the Whitby School in Greenwich, Connecticut. Her children also attended Bridgeview Montessori, each for seven years. With their strong Montessori foundation, her children are both thriving in Vermont colleges (Middlebury and UVM). Suzanne holds a BA in English from Northwestern University as well as a MA in teaching English from Columbia University Teachers College. She is the Kindergarten Librarian and also manages our marketing and outreach. When not at school, Suzanne can be found doing barn chores and riding horses.

Supporting Young Artists with a DIY Home Easel

A PRACTICAL LIFE EXPERIENCE
FOR CHILDREN 16 MONTHS AND UP

by Sarah Moudry



MATERIALS YOU WILL NEED

- Towel bar
- Towel bar brackets
- 18" roll of paper meant for paint
- Contact paper (to protect the wall)
- Vinyl floor mat
- Wall clips
- Magnetic wall strip
- Magnetic container
- Paint cups
- Paint, brushes, chalk, crayons
- Child- and adult-sized aprons

Children love to paint and draw. Are you thinking of adding a painting easel in your home? Or are you frustrated with the amount of space an easel takes up in your house? Many of the easels designed for children are bright, garish in color, plastic, and oversized. Who wants that as a centerpiece in your family space?

Today, we want to share a sturdy, space-saving alternative to an art easel in your home. Children love to paint and draw. Giving them a large surface to do so allows for strength building, provides practice for arm and hand control, and is an open-ended creative exercise they will enjoy. Consider this new install we did at @thestudiojune for a possible art area in your home.

DESIGNING THE SPACE

1. Place contact paper on the wall to protect the wall
2. Decide on the proper height of the paper for your child's height
3. Attach the towel bar at the top of this space
4. Attach the magnetic wall strip at the bottom of this space
5. Slide the paper roll onto the towel bar.
6. Thread the paper behind the magnetic wall strip and out the bottom
7. Attach the wall clips to the wall, where your child can reach and you would like their painting to dry
8. Attach the magnetic container to the magnetic wall strip
9. Prepare the paint in the cups



11. Dip the brush back in the paint.
12. Use a different edge of the brush to make a new stroke on the paper.
13. Repeat dipping the brush in the paint and holding the brush at a new angle to make a new mark.
14. Place the brush in the tray.
15. Close the container of paint.
16. Invite your child to have a turn.
17. Remove the paper and show your child where you can place it to dry.
18. Invite your child to choose a new piece of paper.
19. Invite your child to adhere the paper to the easel and assist if needed.
20. Invite your child to put their paper in a place to dry.
21. Invite your child to repeat as long as they are interested.
22. When they are finished, help them to remove their apron and put it away.

SHARING THE LESSON

1. As with all Practical Life activities, show your child the tools you will need, what they are called, and how to hold them.
2. Remind your child that you will show them how to do the activity, and then they will have a turn.
3. Put on your aprons.
4. Choose a piece of paper.
5. Show your child how to clip the paper to the easel; this will depend on the type of clip and easel you have.
6. Open the paint container and place the lid in the tray of the easel.
7. Hold the paintbrush with a pencil grip.
8. Dip your brush in the paint.
9. Use the tip of the brush to make a stroke on the paper.
10. Look at your child and pause.



Sarah Moudry (@sarahmoudry) is an education innovator whose work is focused on creating education environments and experiences that inspire growth and joy. Her work is rooted in Montessori philosophy and paired with her extensive experience as a designer.

Recently, her projects included the founding of StudioJune (@thestudiojune), a Montessori parent and child education center, and Family Friendly Home (@familyfriendlyhome), an interior design company that creates inspirational home and school interiors.

Sarah is the author of books and online courses that help parents, childcare professionals, and grandparents to incorporate Montessori practice into their lives. She has an MEd in Montessori education, a BS in environment and design; AMI Montessori certification for birth to six years; and is an Associate Member of American Society of Interior Designers.

Play Kitchen

by Cathie Perolman

DEAR CATHIE—

MY DAUGHTER LOVES PLAYING IN HER COUSIN'S PLAY KITCHEN. WHENEVER WE ARE AT HER COUSIN'S HOUSE, SHE GRAVITATES TOWARDS THAT ACTIVITY AND SPENDS A LOT OF TIME THERE. WE HAVE VISITED QUITE A FEW MONTESSORI PROGRAMS, AND WE NOTICE THAT THEY DO NOT HAVE A PLAY COOKING AREA. WE THOUGHT THE MONTESSORI METHOD ENCOURAGED CHILDREN TO DO THINGS THEY WERE INTERESTED IN. WHY DON'T MONTESSORI CLASSROOMS HAVE PLAY KITCHENS?

— PUZZLED PARENTS

Dear Parents,

You are very observant on two counts! Children (even very young children) are naturally drawn to the activities that happen in the kitchen and those that surround eating and cooking. They love to do the things that they see their parents, older siblings, and caregivers do. They are called to be a part of the community happenings surrounding snacks, meals, and food preparation.

Montessori classrooms do not have these activities in play form in their environments. Dr. Maria Montessori noticed that, when given the choice, children were not interested in playing about food preparation. What they were really seeking was real-life experience surrounding food preparation, serving, and cleaning up. They wanted to do the things that adults do with genuine utensils—but the right size for their hands. The Montessori environment does just that. The typical Montessori classroom provides experiences in authentic life activities, such as pouring water from a pitcher for your own snack or serving yourself crackers from a communal bowl. A child

as young as two or three is serving himself food when he is hungry and cleaning up after himself when he is finished. He might also be involved in setting up the lunch for the entire class, putting out placemats, silverware, plates, and glasses. This helps the classroom operate much like a real family, practicing manners and grace and courtesy skills daily.

Children have experiences preparing their own snack. They might spread butter on toast, make their own fruit salad (by counting out three pieces of apple, two pieces of pear, and one grape that they cut in half themselves) or dip three chips in salsa.

The shelf contains self-selected activities that develop these skills at different levels. Children learn to pour from one vessel to another. Later they practice pouring up to a line as they will need to do when they are measuring wet ingredients. They might have an exercise pouring from a pitcher into four glasses, as if they were serving four friends. As the skill level of the class grows, the offerings on the shelves change and the skill level of the entire class grows. These skills come

together in real cooking experiences in the classroom.

Children are shown how to do the things that adults do by breaking the tasks down into small steps and practicing each step until it is mastered. Adults in the environment provide tasks that are appropriate for each child's development. For example, a class might make tomato soup. Younger students might mash one whole canned tomato. Older students might cut the fresh seasoning into small pieces with scissors. A child might cut the bread into squares to make croutons. Others will grate the parmesan cheese. Some children will toss the croutons in the olive oil and in the grated cheese. Using tongs, they will carefully lift each crouton and place it on the cookie sheet where it will toast. The adult will mix the soup using the infusion blender, as that part is too sophisticated for a child. Later, they will add vegetable broth and a small amount of pasta to the soup. (In one class they added whipped cream that the children shook themselves and did not add the pasta.) For snack, the children had tomato soup, ladled out by the child and topped with croutons (counted out by the child). The

Dear Cathie

completion of this exercise provides each child with the pride of accomplishment, as well as the completed product.

Montessori classrooms provide real-life experiences for children to do Practical Life exercises. They do not have any play kitchens or pretend toys. Rather, we have real exercises that practice real skills. These build on each other to help children learn to do more and more complicated sequences of skills, such as baking.

I hope this helps clarify the difference between playing with cooking toys one might see in a home playroom and having real Practical Life and cooking experiences that are a part of the Montessori classroom experience. ■



Cathie Perolman has been involved in Montessori education for over 40 years. Cathie

has worked in the classroom as a 3-6 assistant; a classroom teacher; a level leader; a teacher trainer; and a college professor. She currently spends her time mentoring teachers, conducting workshops for teachers and administrators; and writing for her blog and for magazines. She also serves as a consultant for schools and as a school validator for the Montessori Schools of Maryland. Cathie is the creator of the **Color Coded Sound Games** and the **Rainbow Reading System** as well as other reading and cosmic printable materials to enhance classrooms.

These materials can be found at her website: cathieperolman.com



The Parenting Puzzle

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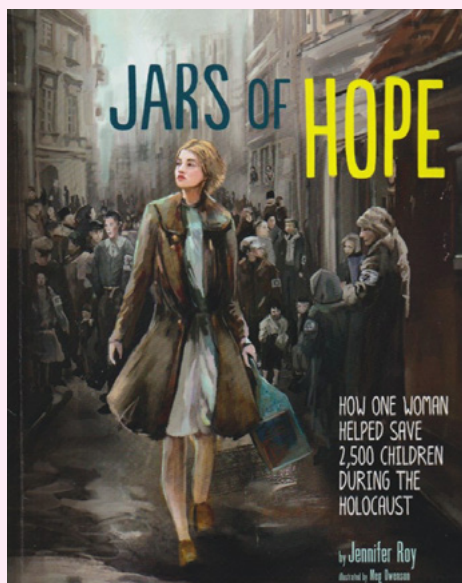
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Irena's Jars of Secrets

Written by Marcia Vaughan

Illustrated by Ron Mazellan



Jars of HOPE

Written by Jennifer Roy

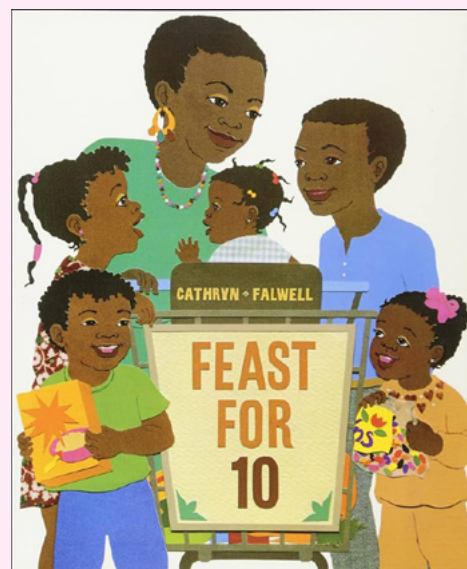
Illustrated by Meg Owenson

These are two different books, written by two different women, creating two slightly different stories, but both are about the same courageous woman: Irena Sendler.

The setting is the beginning of WW II in the Warsaw Ghetto, Poland.

I am always saddened by stories about how unkind humans can be to one another. However, I am lifted up when reading stories of individuals (as well as groups of people) show unbelievable strength and courage in the face of horrific injustice and bias towards others. Irena Sendler and many others banded together for good and were able to rescue so many more Jewish children than any one person could have done on their own.

There is a very informative biography of Irena Sendler at the end of Irena's *Jars of Secrets*. Both books include a glossary and pronunciation guide for readers. These books are amazing history books for children from about 11 through 13 or 14 years old. They can be purchased online.

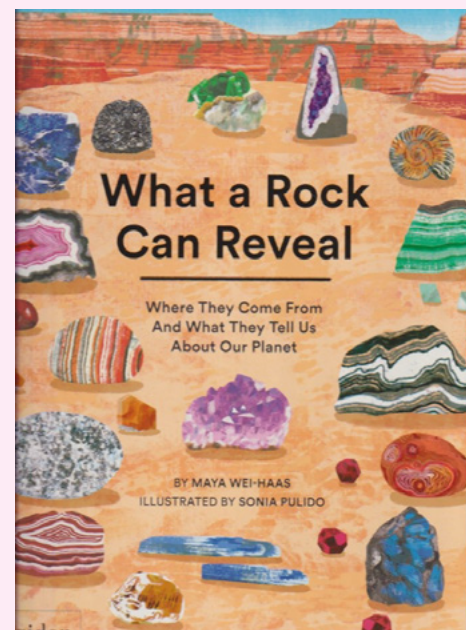


Feast For Ten

Written by Cathryn Falwell

This is a wonderful counting book, wrapped around the story of a family

dinner. It reminded me of Sunday dinners at Gramma's house when I was a child. It tells the story of a family meal from the grocery store to the dinner table. Counting all the way from 1-10, shopping at the store and then starting all over again with taking the food out of the car. It demonstrates how a family can happily work together to create a wonderful meal for everyone, all while counting the carrots, the bunches of greens, the cooks, the chairs, the plates, etc. Children will enjoy this fun book. It is available online.



What a Rock Can Reveal

Written by Maya Wei-Haas
(a Montessori graduate)

Illustrated by Sonia Pulido

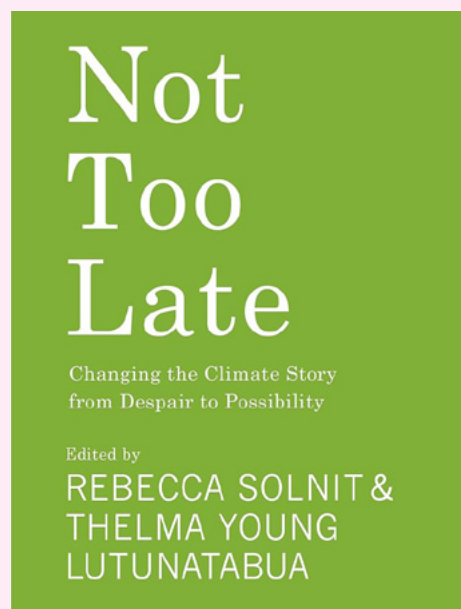
What a wonderful book for the Elementary years! Maya Wei-Haas knows just how to engage the curiosity of those inquisitive and imaginative minds. She is a Montessori school graduate, who

is now a scientist and writer. Her experience as a Montessori student, I am quite sure, influenced how she organized the book, providing easy-to-understand information. She answers many questions and offers many real-life examples and experiences.

Sonia Pulido's illustrations are colorful and realistic, inclusive of the children and places around the world. She depicts the kinds of events referenced in the book (i.e., volcanoes, earthquakes, and tectonic plates).

I really didn't want to put this book down, and it's relatively long but that shouldn't stop anyone from reading this captivating book. I would suggest that adults could easily divide the book into sections and do one at a time. As I read it, I was reminded of baking soda and vinegar volcanoes, rock tumblers for smoothing stones, telescopes for watching the night skies, caverns underground for visiting, and more. There could be all kinds of adventures and experiments to supplement the reading. I can't wait for my almost 8-year-old grandson to visit so we can

start looking at rocks and their stories. This is a book for home and school libraries for sure. It can be purchased at most bookstores online or in person.



**Not Too Late:
Changing the Climate
Story from Despair to
Possibility**

Edited by Rebecca Solnit & Thelma Young Lutunatabua

This book is a collection of articles written by people from many different

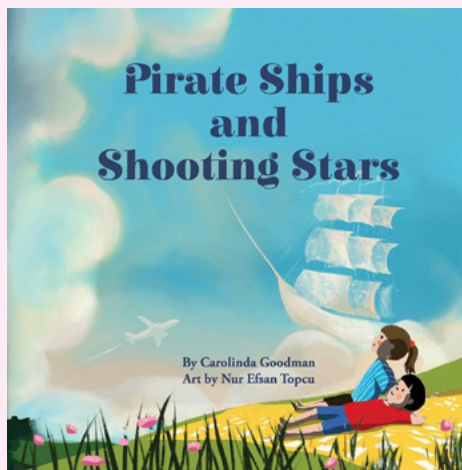
organizations, occupations, and countries from around the world who are interested, knowledgeable, and committed to making change in our world. There can be no “pollyanna” or “pie-in-the-sky” thinking about the changes that have happened and continue to happen on earth. However, there is hope and resilience in humans across the globe. The articles in this book inform us about some of those humans, the actions they are taking, and information gathered.

The importance of reading *Not Too Late* should not be underestimated or overlooked by anyone who has a child or who cares for children. All of us are being affected by reports of the state of the world that we see and hear every day. As adults, it's our responsibility to help our children to develop resilience and hope even in challenging times. One way to do that is by reading this book. It will help bolster your resilience and hope. Through our attitudes and actions, children will absorb our renewed spirit and become empowered themselves. In this day and time, I suggest that this is a must read for

CALLING ALL TEACHERS, PARENTS, & CHILDREN!

We would love to publish reviews
of your favorite books. Send book
reviews to Lorna at:
lornamcgrath@montessori.org

parents, teachers, and all adults who influence children's lives. It can be purchased online or in bookstores.



Pirate Ships and Shooting Stars

Written by Carolinda Goodman

Illustrated by Nur Efsan Topcu

Wow! This is a book that I had tucked away and found again the other day.

Turns out, I've had it for almost two years now. Anyway, today I finally read it. It's grand!

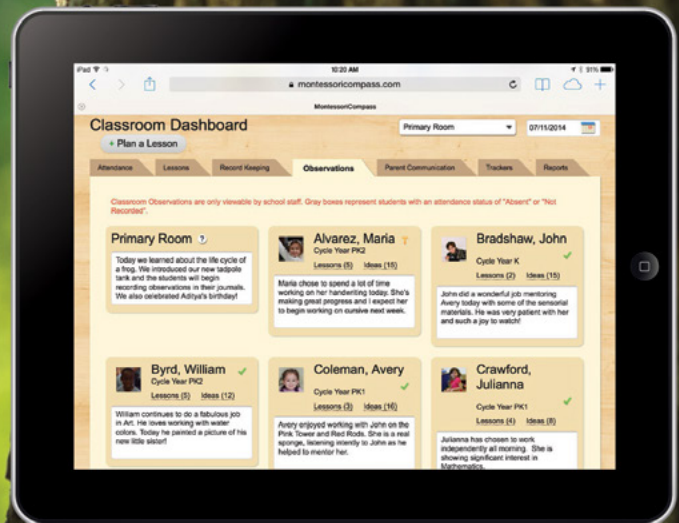
Carolinda wrote the text in rhyme, which young children love so much. It's all about the sky and what we can see up there if we use our imaginations. There are pictures, stories, and even shows if we just take the time to look up and see. First the author looks at the sky during the day, starting with sunrise, then pictures in the clouds, sometimes rainbows, or clear skies open for our imaginations to soar! Later, of course, there's the sunset, the moon and stars, constellations, shooting stars, and more.

I love the excitement and enthusiasm for watching the sky with all its wonders that the author brings to readers.

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